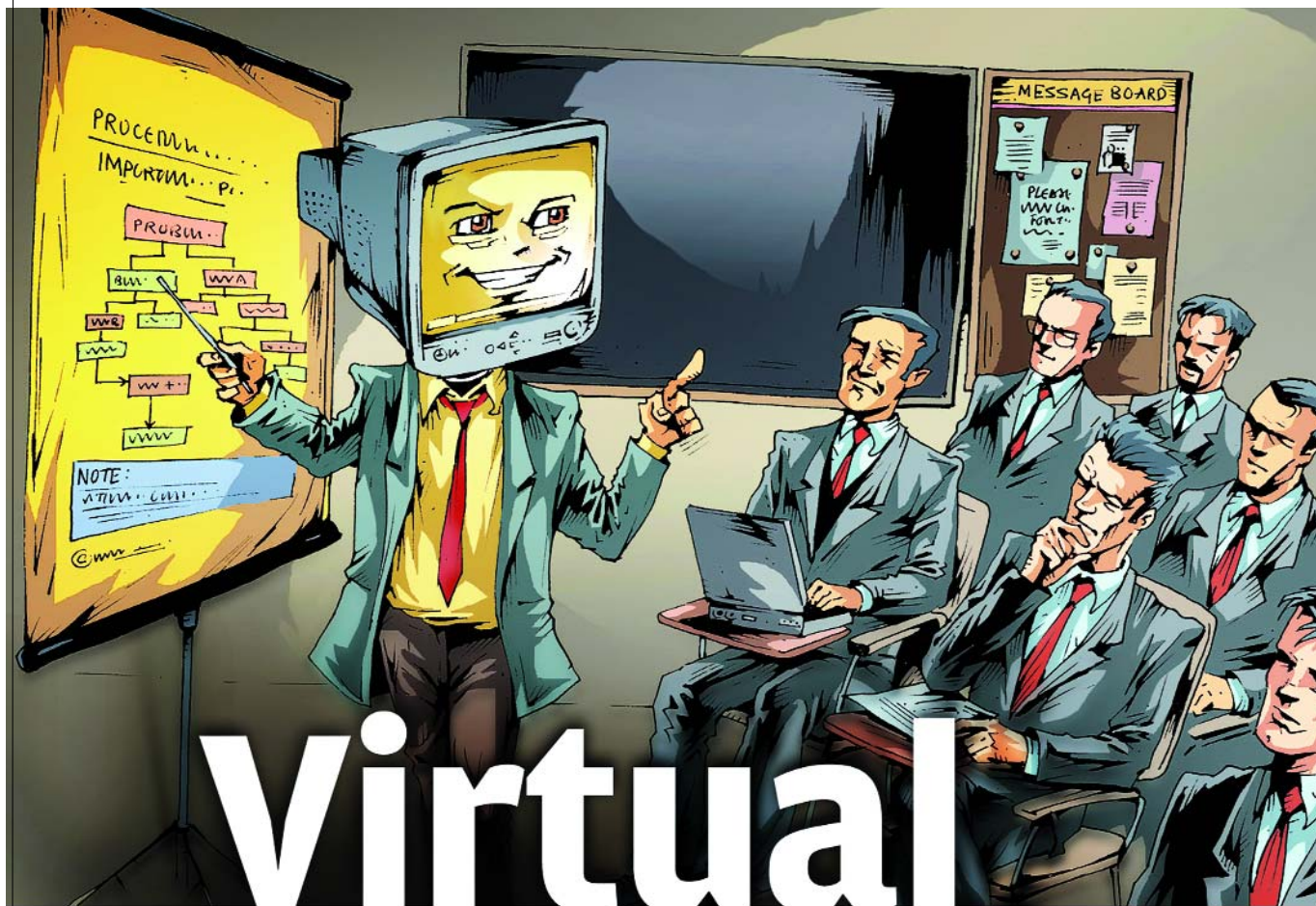




Virtual Classrooms

'E' has become the most used alphabet in computer terminology. E-learning - the use of electronic medium for training in the corporate world - joins the club

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In a knowledge-based economy, ignorance is tantamount to commercial suicide. As a company you are keenly aware of this Darwinian fact of evolve or perish. To know is thus essential, but when knowledge shifts and evolves at the speed of the Internet, keeping pace becomes the order of the day. Thankfully, Janus-faced technology once again submits both the challenge and a solution to the problem in the form of e-learning.

E-learning: while the word may not be listed in the Oxford dictionary, there are a lot of definitions floating around for the same. Learnframe.com, for example, defines e-learning as, 'Education via the Internet, network or stand-alone computer... a network-enabled transfer of skills and knowledge. E-learning refers to using electronic applications and processes to learn. E-learning applications and processes include Web-based learning, computer-based learning, virtual classrooms, and digital collaboration. Content is delivered via the Internet, intranet/extranet, audio or video tape, satellite TV and CD-ROM.' This definition plainly under-

lines the extent to which the electronic medium is involved in this type of education.

Most large companies today are using e-learning as a cost-effective method of delivering knowledge to an enterprise audience. However, finding the best e-learning solution to fit their scale and budget is still a challenge that many business divisions face. Let us examine a few real-world implementations with a view to understanding how to best utilise this tool for your company.

What is E-learning?

E-learning is extensively used by companies today, mainly due to the convenience involved. Business is no longer restricted to geographical boundaries. It thus becomes very essential that vital information be communicated across locations. The accurate dissemination of such information to a wide audience is a big challenge. If done in the traditional way of classroom training, it can be a very tedious process, perhaps even more expensive.

E-learning removes geography from the picture. An individual working on a project in the US may need help from his team in India. Rather than sending an e-mail and waiting for a reply,